Next morning, coming out of our hotel, we saw our friends bent over shoe shine boxes beside the fountain in the public square, doing brisk business.



We watched for a few moments; then as trade **slackened** we went over. They greeted us with friendly faces.

"I thought you picked fruit for a living, "I said." We do many things, sir," Nicola answered seriously. He glanced at us hopefully. "Often we show visitors through the town ... to Juliet's tomb ... and other places of interest."

"All right," I smiled. "You take us along."

As we made the rounds, my interest was again provoked by their remarkable **demeanour.** They were childish enough, and in many ways quite **artless.** Jacopo was lively as a squirrel. Nicola's smile was steady and engaging. Yet in both these boyish faces there was a seriousness which was far beyond their years. In the week which followed we saw them frequently, for they proved extremely useful to us. If we wanted a pack of American cigarettes, or seats for the opera or the name of good restaurant, Nicola and Jacopo could be relied upon to satisfy our needs. What struck one most was their willingness to work. During these summer days, under the hot sun, they shined shoes, sold fruit, **hawked** newspapers, conducted tourists round the town, and ran errands.

One night, we came upon them in the windy and **deserted** square, resting on the stone pavement beneath the lights. Nicola sat upright, tired. A bundle of unsold newspapers lay at his feet. Jacopo, his head resting upon his brother's shoulder was asleep. It was nearly midnight.

"Why are you out so late, Nicola?"

"Waiting for the last bus from Padua. We shall sell all our papers when it comes in."

"Must you work so hard? You both look rather tired."

"We are not complaining, sir."

But next morning, when I went over to the fountain to have my shoes shined, I said, "Nicola, the way you and Jacopo work, you must earn quite a bit. You spend nothing on clothes. You eat little enough --- when I see you have a meal it's usually black bread and figs. Tell me, what do you do with your money?"

He coloured deeply under his sunburn and then grew pale. He looked to the ground.

"You must be saving up to **emigrate** to America," I suggested. He looked at me sideways, spoke with an effort.

"We should greatly like to go to the States. But here, at present, we have other plans."



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